IN THE SHADOW OF GRACE

The Story of Pastor Joseph Tamang

Sanjiv Rai

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In loving memory of Late Marium Tamang, mother of Joseph Tamang

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Preface

The story behind how I got the inspiration to write this book is that one fine day, we were sipping tea and having a conversation with Reverend Joseph Tamang about his life. After hearing his remarkable story, it dawned on me that his biography needed to be written as I felt that his story needs to be heard by more people.

I also reflected on my own observation about how we read and are familiar with the stories and lives of people such as Martin Luther, Billy Graham, William Carey and other great personalities who have indeed made significant contributions to the Christendom which have left an indelible impact and continue to inspire us even long after they have been gone. However, many of us are unaware of great faithful men of God from our own region who have also made noteworthy contributions to our society in various ways and impacted the lives of many people. Joseph Tamang is one such person whose faithful service to God and his community has made a significant positive impact on the lives of countless people. Hence, I decided to embark on a journey to gather more information about his inspiring life from different sources and put pen to paper.

This work is an endeavour to capture his life story starting from his early childhood days in Monsong to how he came to Gangtok as a young boy and later, went on to put his faith in Christ and how God has been using his life ever since, to

bring light and hope to the lives of many people. I hope that this book will be a blessing to our readers and inspire them also to find their God-given purpose and work for the Kingdom of God with their own unique sets of gifts that they have been blessed with.

Acknowledgements

I would firstly like to thank Rev. Joseph Tamang who is the inspiration behind and the primary source of this book. Despite his busy schedule and the challenges of old age, Rev. Joseph graciously agreed to set aside an ample amount of time for us, providing us with all the important details about his life that needed to be written and told to the world . In every interview, he was open and sincere, even when we discussed sensitive or potentially embarrassing subjects. His willingness to share his life's journey including the highs and the lows, has been the cornerstone of this biography.

For background information on Rev. Joseph, I owe a debt of gratitude to his wife, Mrs. Lydia Tamang, his eldest sister, and other family members. Their insights and support were crucial in bringing this work to completion in its present form.

I am deeply grateful to the Naya Drishti team members, whose patience and support were invaluable, especially during moments when I found myself stuck in the process and also, for editing the manuscript.

Above all, I would like to thank our mighty God and King whom we serve and live for. It is for His glory alone that we do what we do. Soli Deo Gloria.

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Chapter One

A Mother's Journey with Her Eight Children

During the twilight of the British rule in India, as the country stood on the brink of reclaiming its freedom and celebrating victory, the small village of Monsong in West Bengal was home to Harka Singh Tamang and his wife, Fulmati Tamang. The couple lived a happy married life, embodying the resilience and spirit of the Indian people during that period.

On October 21, 1940, Fulmati gave birth to their third child, a baby boy whom they named Kubir Tamang. Kubir had three older brothers, two older sisters, and two younger brothers, making the family a bustling household of ten. Fulmati's life was far from easy, as she bore the responsibility of caring for their eight children.

Kubir Tamang could not receive much love and care from his parents, as his mother spent much of her time in the fields, often leaving Kubir in the care of his sisters. Harka Singh, on the other hand, was a witch doctor, who claimed to heal people through magical powers. He was not much of a family man and spent most of his time traveling and trying to heal people. When Harka Singh was away, Fulmati and her children lived in fear. Their lives were fraught with challenges, and Fulmati never knew what each day would bring.

When Kubir Tamang turned eight, his father passed away. Fulmati was in complete shock and did not know what to do with her life. She contemplated ending

her life, but the love for her children stopped her from doing so. The thought of feeding eight children as a single mother seemed impossible to her. Kubir's older brothers and sisters helped their mother during the tough times, but Kubir was too young to understand the situation his family was going through. He would often look into his mother's eyes and see tears, not knowing why they were there. He was too young to comprehend the loss of his father.

Kubir used to go to the forest with his mother to fetch grass for their cattle and goats. His brothers did not attend school as the circumstances of their family did not allow them to, but Kubir had different aspirations. He wanted to study. Later, his eldest brother moved to Darjeeling and got married. He then called Kubir to live with him. With the help of his eldest brother, Kubir enrolled in Turnbull High School in Darjeeling where he studied until the fourth standard. He could not continue living with his brother after that and he decided to leave. The reason was that his brother's wife mistreated Kubir when his brother was not at home. When Kubir would share these incidents with his brother, that often led to fights between them. As he felt responsible for the conflicts, Kubir decided to leave his brother's house and return to his mother in Monsong. As there were no telephones then, he could not inform his mother of his decision to return and had to travel back to Monsong from Darjeeling on his own. He could never attend school again. Watching his friends go to school would make him cry, but no one understood his desire to study. He could not express his desire to his mother, who was already burdened with tremendous hardship.

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Kubir left the train of his education, realizing that life is not the same for everyone. When he would see his friends doing their homework after coming back from school, he would miss his schooldays at Turnbull High School. However, he found consolation in the fact that he had at least learned to read and write during his time there. Now, he takes pride in the education that he was able to receive, and he still cherishes the memories of his school life.

While Kubir was experiencing his own struggles, his mother was waging an even greater battle. Kubir recalled that they had slept without food on many nights. The severity of their hardship led his eldest sister to leave home and get married to a man in Sikkim. Aware of their mother's struggles, she hoped to alleviate some of the burden, but she soon found herself overwhelmed by the responsibilities of her own family.

One evening, Kubir and his mother received a message from his eldest sister, urging them to leave Monsong and come to Sikkim, where she had found a job for their mother. For Fulmati, leaving everything behind was not at all easy, as she cherished the memories of her husband in Monsong. Initially, she hesitated to leave for Sikkim. Kubir, who had never been to Sikkim, was curious and asked his mother, "Is Sikkim also a village, or is it like Darjeeling?" She replied, "Sikkim is a different country, and it is close to China." Kubir was thrilled at the prospect of going to Sikkim and insisted that his mother agree to the move.

This story takes place in 1955 when Sikkim was an independent kingdom, much like Bhutan is today. King Tashi Namgyal was the reigning monarch in Sikkim during that time. After a month of contemplation, Kubir's mother decided to leave Monsong and travel to Sikkim. She sold all her cattle and goats, thereby earning a modest sum. Their neighbors mocked them, calling the decision foolish and saying that leaving their land for a foreign country was unwise. Despite the criticism, they remained resolute and did not heed the neighbors' words.

Phulmati asked her sons and daughters to pack their clothes and roasted some corn for the journey. They traveled on foot from Monsong to the Rangpo-Sikkim border. It was not an easy feat for a single mother to walk through the forest with her children, but Kubir recalled, "My mother was a very strong lady, willing to do anything for the sake of her children." As they walked through the Monsong Jungle, Kubir felt very thirsty and asked his mother for some water. She told him, "Wait, we will drink when we reach Rangpo." Kubir cried because he was thirsty and tired. His mother then went into the forest, came back with some water in a large leaf, and gave it to him. Kubir still cries when he remembers the sacrifices that his mother had made for him throughout her life.

After a tiring journey, they finally reached the Rangpo border, and felt elated at the sight of a new land awaiting them. However, they still had more traveling to do from Rangpo to Gangtok. In those days, the only modes of transportation available

from Rangpo to Gangtok were a bullock cart and an old wooden Kasturi bus. They chose to travel by the wooden Kasturi bus. The fare for the trip was three rupees.

After the tiring journey, they finally reached Gangtok. Kubir's eldest sister was waiting for them, and Kubir was overjoyed to see her face. Gangtok was a completely new place for them, and they did not know anyone else there. As Kubir and his mother walked along the roads of Gangtok, they had no idea what challenges awaited them. Kubir's mother had to finally start working. She was assigned the job to take care of the daughter of a man named Isaac Lepcha and to cook food for the family. She worked as a househelp at the Lepcha residence.

Isaac provided them with a small room in his old chicken coop. Phulmati covered the coop with a plastic sheet and made it their new home. Kubir and his mother began their life in Sikkim in that chicken coop. Kubir's mother struggled immensely as she had numerous tasks to perform at Isaac’s house. After finishing her work there, she had to continue with her housework at her home. Her life became increasingly miserable. Kubir, aware of his mother's suffering, began to seek a job and after some effort, he was able to find work as a domestic help in a Bengali household.

Kubir recalled, "Working in that house was the darkest period of my life." His employer called him “Bahadur” derogatorily and sometimes made him cook in the middle of the night. Gangtok was extremely cold, and Kubir did not have any warm clothes. He found it difficult to wake up at night and work. "Many times, my tears

would fall on the floor, and I wondered why my life was like that," he said. Despite the hardships, he did not want to return to his mother because he knew her situation full well.

Later, Kubir learned that his mother had embraced Christianity. Isaac Lepcha had preached about Christ to Phulmati, and she had decided to follow Jesus Christ. Meanwhile, Kubir was extremely unhappy with his employer, and after a year, he returned home to join his mother. Kubir also began attending CNI Church in Gangtok with his mother, although he knew very little about Christ and was essentially only a nominal Christian. At the church, the pastor gave Phulmati a new Christian name, Marium Tamang. Kubir jokingly told his mother that she was like a new baby with a new name. However, he did not know yet what the future held for his mother.

One morning, Kubir heard his mother scream in pain, and he rushed to her. As he held her, he asked her, "What happened?" She replied weakly, "I am having a severe pain in my stomach." With the assistance of some church members, Kubir took his mother to the old Thendup Hospital in Gangtok. Despite the doctors' best efforts to save her life, she took her last breath on Kubir's lap. Kubir felt a profound sense of loss and helplessness. Kubir's world shattered into pieces; he found himself utterly alone. As he had never received his father's love, his mother had meant the world to him. Now, with her gone, he felt like his world had collapsed. Despite the church leaders' attempts to console him, his tears continued to flow endlessly, like the rain. This tragic event marked the beginning of a new and difficult chapter in Kubir's life.

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Phulmati, who was later known as Marium, had faced her struggles with remarkable strength. Her story challenges every mother to learn from her resilience and to fight tirelessly for the sake of their children, even in the face of overwhelming odds.

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Chapter Two

Life without A Mother

Kubir's journey had become increasingly difficult, with the memories of his mother still fresh in his heart. He said that, on many nights, his pillow would be soaked with tears. "Losing a loving mother," he remarked, "is like losing your world." Despite his grief, Kubir had to overcome his mourning and find work in order to survive. The harsh realities of his situation did not allow him to even mourn or deal with his broken heart. With the help of his former employer, he managed to find a job as a sweeper.

Kubir became a sweeper, tasked with cleaning the drains at Raj Bhawan in Gangtok. His childhood had been filled with pain, and now his youth seemed to be leading him towards further hardship. He spoke about the difficulties of working during the winter, when the cold made his job even more challenging.

He recounted a time when he caught a severe cold and developed a high fever. He had no one to care for him, and he was unable to cook or even boil water. On that day, he longed for the comforting touch of his mother. That night, he saw her in his dream. In the dream, she was calling out to him with her arms wide open. As he ran towards her, he tripped over a stone and fell. At that moment, he woke up, finding himself alone in the room.

The next day was Sunday, and despite his fever, Kubir went to church. The church members tried to console him and encouraged him not to lose hope. Kubir was

not a devout Christian; he attended church only because of the memories of his mother as he used to accompany her to church in the past. He would often feel bored during the services.

His work as a sweeper was especially challenging during the summer due to the heavy rains. He had to ensure that the drains were clean so that the water could flow smoothly. Gradually, Kubir made friends at work, and he began to find enjoyment in his daily tasks. During those days, Sikkim was very sparsely populated and even Gangtok resembled a jungle. After 6 pm, people used to be afraid to walk along the roads to Gangtok, as it would be eerily dark which also led to a fear of being attacked by wild animals. Entertainment options were almost non-existent, leaving many to face their loneliness and fears alone.

Kubir too, felt a deep sense of isolation. The evenings were the hardest for him, as the memories of his mother and his solitary life would weigh heavily on his heart. The lack of companionship and the constant struggle for survival left him feeling desolate. His new friends at work were the only source of comfort, but even their company could not fill the void left by his mother's absence. Each night, as he lay on his thin mattress, he longed for the warmth and comfort of his mother's presence. The sounds from the jungle outside his window only amplified his sense of vulnerability and loneliness. Yet, amid these hardships, Kubir found a quiet strength

within himself. The support of his newfound friends and the lessons of resilience he had learnt from his past began to shape his journey.

At the age of 22, Kubir began to think about getting married. However, he did not think it likely that anyone would be willing to get married to him, given his humble background and lack of a proper house. Yet, God had different plans for Kubir. Divine providence was about to bring a ray of joy into his life.

One day, Kubir met a girl who would turn his life around. Her name was Khusha Rai. She was very beautiful, and her home was very close to Kubir's. Their paths crossed frequently, and they slowly formed a bond. With both hope and trepidation, Kubir shared his desire to marry her. To his immense joy, Khusha accepted his proposal. Khusha brought light into Kubir's world, and filled the void in his heart that was created by years of hardship and loneliness. Her presence was a balm to his soul, and he found himself smiling more often. The happiness he felt was beyond words; Khusha's love made him feel whole for the first time in a long while.

The simple moments they shared — walking together, talking about their dreams, and laughing at life's little quirks — became treasures for Kubir. He felt a renewed sense of purpose and hope. Khusha not only accepted him but also embraced his past and his dreams for the future. Their love story was a living proof that even in the harshest of circumstances, love can blossom and bring profound joy. Kubir's life,

once shadowed by sorrow and solitude, now gleamed with the promise of a brighter tomorrow.

In those days, it was not as easy to stay in regular communication as it is today. There were no mobile phones for instant communication, and even writing a letter was a challenge due to scarcity of pen and paper. Despite these obstacles, Kubir and Khusha's love for each other grew stronger.

Finally, the time came for them to decide on marriage. Given the societal constraints and their differing religious backgrounds, Kubir and Khusha chose to elope. They got married in secret in the year 1970, unaware of the consequences that this would bring. Kubir, a Christian, did not know that marrying someone outside the faith in this manner was not endorsed in his faith. Khusha, on the other hand, was a Hindu, and her family found it difficult to accept a Christian as their son-in-law.

In those days, Christians were usually looked down upon, and many Hindu families would not allow Christians to enter their homes. Kubir and Khusha faced considerable opposition from her family and the community. Their love was tested by the prejudices and rigid customs of the time. Khusha's family disowned her, forbidding her from visiting even her mother and father. Isolated from her relatives, Khusha and Kubir began their life together, facing the challenges of their new reality with determination.

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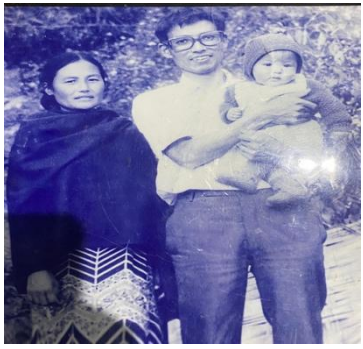
In the beginning, Khusha did not attend church and even discouraged Kubir from going. For her, Christianity was an entirely unfamiliar way of life. Kubir, who himself had limited knowledge of the Bible and Christianity, found it difficult to explain his faith to her convincingly. Despite these religious differences, their love for each other remained strong. They navigated their new life with patience and understanding. Khusha's reluctance to embrace Christianity was met with Kubir's gentle acceptance, which reflected the deep bond that they shared. Kubir's lack of theological knowledge meant that he was not able to expound the Scriptures to her, but his actions spoke louder than words. His kindness and love were a clear demonstration of his beliefs, even though he could not articulate them fully.

Chapter Three

Journey from Kubir to Joseph

Kubir Tamang's life journey was marked by ups and downs, after marriage as well. After the birth of their first child, Mahindra Tamang, Kubir began to struggle with alcoholism. This challenge caused him to withdraw from his community and church, feeling that it was a place reserved only for the wealthy. His wife, too, showed little interest in attending church, which only deepened their sense of isolation.

The family faced numerous challenges during this time, but their story also has its moments of joy. Following the birth of Mahindra, Kubir and his wife were blessed with two daughters, Dorces Tamang and Rebika Tamang. The arrival of these two girls into their lives brought immense happiness to them, offering a much-needed sense of renewal and hope. Their family continued to grow, and they were later blessed with two more sons, Samson Tamang and Simon Tamang.



Young Joseph Tamang and his wife Lediya Tamang with their son, Simon Tamang

The addition of these two boys completed their family, filling their home with even more love and joy. Despite the difficulties they faced, the presence of their children became a source of strength for Kubir and his wife, helping them navigate the challenges of life together.

One day, Isaac Lepcha reached out to Kubir Tamang and invited him to join him on a house visitation. Together, they went to the home of Albert Karthak, where Albert's uncle was gravely ill. It was there, in Albert Karthak's home, that Kubir had a life-changing encounter with Albert's grandmother, affectionately known as Ajii—a term of endearment for “grandmother" in their culture. Ajii, despite her advanced age and tremor in her voice, possessed a captivating presence, especially when she spoke of Jesus Christ. During that first meeting, she shared with Kubir the teachings of the Bible, urging him to return for more. Drawn by her wisdom and the warmth of her words, Kubir began to visit Ajii regularly. Each visit deepened his interest in the teachings of Christ, and he soon found himself engrossed in the Bible, inspired by Ajii's passion and unwavering faith.

Over time, Ajii noticed Kubir's growing dedication. One day, she called him aside and said, "Kubir, your name is not from the Bible but there is a biblical character whose story is similar to yours and I feel compelled to give you his name." Very curious, Kubir asked, "Who would that be? What will my Christian name be?" With a gentle smile, Ajii bestowed on him the name “Joseph”, a name she felt was befitting

of his journey. She then prayed over him, thus, marking the beginning of a new chapter in his life, one that would be defined by faith, transformation, and a deeper connection to the teachings of Christ.

Filled with joy, Kubir hurried home to share the news with his wife. "I am no longer Kubir", he announced with excitement, "from now on, I am Joseph Tamang." At first, his wife could not help but laugh at the the news of this sudden decision to change his name. However, as she observed the transformation in Joseph's life — his newfound sense of purpose and devotion — her curiosity grew. The man she had known for years was evolving before her very eyes, and she found herself drawn to the source of his change.

Ajii, aware of this, invited both Joseph and his wife to her home once again. During this visit, she spoke to Joseph's wife about Jesus Christ with the same passion and gentle wisdom that had captivated Joseph. Ajii saw in her the potential for a similar transformation and said, "You will no longer be known as Khusha. From today onwards, you will be Lediya Tamang."

The couple, now known as Joseph and Lediya Tamang, embraced these new names given by Ajii, symbolizing not just a change in identity, but a rebirth in their spiritual journey. This moment marked a significant turning point in their lives, as they both found a renewed sense of purpose and a deeper connection to their faith. They began seeking a church in Gangtok where they could nurture their newfound faith and

raise their family. Their search led them to Bethlehem Church in Gangtok, where they met R.S. Yonjon Graham, a spiritual mentor who would play a crucial role in nurturing their growth in Christ. Under the guidance of R.S. Yonjon Graham, Joseph and his entire family deepened their understanding of Christian teachings. This journey of faith reached a significant milestone when they decided to be baptized. In a solemn ceremony, Atal Tamang baptized them in the name of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit, marking the formal beginning of their Christian journey.

This newfound faith brought immense joy and a renewed sense of purpose to their lives. Joseph and Marium became active members of Bethlehem Church, attending every fellowship and thanking God for the transformation that they had experienced through Jesus Christ. Their hearts were filled with gratitude for the new life they had embraced. Unaware of the full extent of God's plan, Joseph found himself gradually being drawn into a deeper mission. In 1988, he made a pivotal decision: to dedicate his life to the expansion of God's kingdom. At that time, resources such as access to Bible colleges or formal training centers or even Christian literature were scarce, leaving Joseph and Lediya to rely solely on their faith and the guidance of the Holy Spirit.

Undeterred by the lack of formal education in ministry, Joseph and his wife turned to prayer, seeking divine assistance in their mission. They asked God for wisdom, strength, and direction as they ventured into this new calling. Day by day,

with God's guidance, they grew — both in their understanding of His Word and in their ability to serve their community. Their progress was slow, but steady. Each step they took was rooted in faith, and as they trusted in God's plan, they found themselves increasingly equipped for the work that they had been called to do.

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Chapter Four

God’s Mission through Joseph and Nagamese people

Joseph with his wife, Lediya decided to start a new fellowship at their house. For an entire year, Joseph and his family were the sole attendees of their house church. Despite the small congregation, Joseph preached faithfully every Sunday with unwavering dedication. Although his knowledge of the Bible was only rudimentary, Joseph relied deeply on the guidance of the Holy Spirit to preach his sermons.

Each week, Joseph stood before his small gathering delivering messages of faith and hope. Though most of the seats remained empty, his conviction never wavered. He believed that God had called him to this mission, and he trusted that in time, the seeds he was planting would bear fruit. This period of isolation and perseverance tested Joseph's faith, but it also deepened it. With every sermon, he grew not only in his understanding of the Bible but also in his dependence on the Holy Spirit.

In another part of the country, a powerful revival was sweeping through Nagaland in the early 1990s, igniting a wave of spiritual fervor that would have far-reaching effects. During a time of fasting and prayer at the Chatey Prayer Tower, the Nagamese believers received a prophecy from their pastor, instructing them to go to the land of Sikkim. This directive left them perplexed, as none of them had ever set foot in Sikkim, and they were uncertain of what awaited them there. The news of this

revival and prophecy soon reached Dr. Kut, a prominent minister in Nagaland. Recognizing the significance of this spiritual movement, Dr. Kut felt compelled to support the mission and decided to sponsor the group through the tourism department.

Thus, a group of Nagamese believers embarked on their journey to Sikkim. Upon arriving in Gangtok, they were welcomed by representatives of the Sikkim Tourism Department, who had arranged their accommodation at Namgyal Hotel. The Nagamese group, eager to fulfill their prophetic mission, began exploring Gangtok, searching for the right person to share their vision. However, they struggled to find anyone who could understand the significance of the purpose of the long journey that they had undertaken. Frustrated and unsure of their next step, the leader of the group approached the manager of the hotel and asked, "Is there any Christian here, or a church we could visit?" The manager who was familiar with the local Christian community, provided a name that would soon prove pivotal: Joseph Tamang. This introduction marked the beginning of a deep connection between Joseph and the Nagamese believers.

When Joseph finally met with the Nagamese group, they faced an immediate challenge — communication. Joseph was not fluent in English, nor could he understand the Nagamese language. Inspite of the language barrier, the Nagamese group was moved by Joseph's dedication and the evident work of the Holy Spirit in his life. They were convinced that God had indeed led them to the right person. With this

shared sense of purpose, the Nagamese believers decided to support Joseph in his mission. This partnership led to Joseph working under the banner of Rengma Baptist Church in Sikkim, marking a new phase in his ministry. What began as a chance encounter blossomed into a collaboration that would further the mission of spreading the Christian faith in the region.

In 1992, Joseph expanded his mission work to the village of Nimtar, a place untouched by the Christian faith. With unwavering faith and reliance on God's grace, he began sharing the message of Christ with the local people. Among those who heard his message were Naren Karki and Jona Tamang, both of whom were impacted deeply by Joseph's teachings. Jona Tamang was the first from his family to embrace Christianity, making a bold and courageous decision to follow Christ despite being alone in his faith. Inspired by the transformation he witnessed in his own life and the lives of others, Jona, along with Joseph, decided it was time to establish a church in Nimtar.

With prayer and dedication, they chose a plot of land belonging to Hemlal Chettri as the site for their new church. They built a place of worship, a sanctuary where the people of Nimtar could gather to learn about Christ and grow in their faith. Every Sunday, Joseph and his family would make the journey from Gangtok to Nimtar, providing fellowship and spiritual guidance to the fledgling congregation.

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First Baptist Church of Sikkim at Nimtar, East Sikkim

During this time, the Rengma Baptist Church in Nagaland provided Joseph with a monthly honorarium of five hundred rupees. Although it was a modest amount, this support provided tremendous encouragement to Joseph, which fueled his passion and determination to work even harder for God's mission. The church in Nimtar became a symbol of hope and faith, a testament to what could be achieved through dedication, prayer, and an unwavering belief in God's plan.

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In 2007, Joseph Tamang's spiritual journey took a significant turn when Rengma Baptist Church of Nagaland ordained him as a pastor for the Sikkim mission field. From that moment on, Joseph never looked back. Embracing his new role with unwavering dedication, he committed his life entirely to the service of Christ. Every step he took was guided by his deep faith, and every action reflected his resolve to spread the message of hope and redemption.

Ordination of Joseph Tamang as Pastor with his wife, Lediya Tamang on the right

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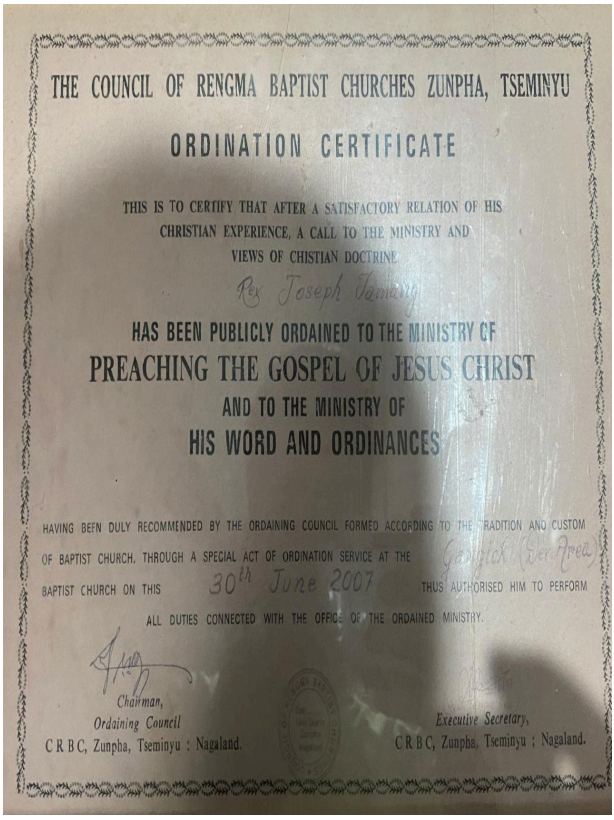

THE COUNCIL OF RENGMA BAPTIST CHURCHES ZUNPHA, TSEMINYU

ORDINATION CERTIFICATE

THIS IS TO CERTIFY THAT AFTER A SATISFACTORY RELATION OF HIS CHRISTIAN EXPERIENCE, A CALL TO THE MINISTRY AND VIEWS OF CHISTIAN DOCTRINE

Rev Joseph Tamang

HAS BEEN PUBLICLY ORDAINED TO THE MINISTRY OF

PREACHING THE GOSPEL OF JESUS CHRIST

AND TO THE MINISTRY OF

HIS WORD AND ORDINANCES

HAVING BEEN DULY RECOMMENDED BY THE ORDAINING COUNCIL FORMED ACCORDING TO THE TRADITION AND CUSTOM OF BAPTIST CHURCH, THROUGH A SPECIAL ACT OF ORDINATION SERVICE AT THE Gerlick (Ser Area) BAPTIST CHURCH ON THIS 30th June 2007 THUS AUTHORISED HIM TO PERFORM ALL DUTIES CONNECTED WITH THE OFFICE OF THE ORDAINED MINISTRY.

Chairman,
Ordaining Council
C R B C, Zunpha, Tseminyu : Nagaland.

Executive Secretary,
C R B C, Zunpha, Tseminyu : Nagaland.

Ordination Certificate of Joseph Tamang from the Council of Rengma Baptist Churches

Joseph's ordination marked the beginning of a lifelong mission that has seen him touch countless lives. His work, fueled by an unshakable belief in his calling, has been a source of strength and inspiration to those around him. From the day of his ordination to the present, Joseph Tamang has remained steadfast in his devotion, giving everything he has to serve others in the name of Christ.

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Chapter Five

Mission and Challenges

Joseph's journey from Gangtok to Nimtar every Sunday became a challenging one for him and his family. The regular commute took its toll on his health, and after much deliberation, they decided to settle down in Nimtar. It was a difficult decision, leaving behind the land in Gangtok that held so many memories of his late mother. However, with a deep sense of purpose and a commitment to put God's mission first, Joseph made the brave choice to relocate.

In 1995, Joseph, along with his family, fully established their new home in Nimtar. The transition to a new place was made easier thanks to the warm hospitality and support of the local community. Families like those of Jona Tamang and Naren Karki welcomed them with open arms, offering their help and companionship as they settled into their new environment. This sense of community made it easier for them to adapt to this big life change and embrace their new life in Nimtar.

Joseph's first house at Nimtar (1995)

Joseph started his journey with humble beginnings, raising his five children with very limited resources. The challenge of providing them with quality education weighed heavily on him, as he did not have the means to invest in their schooling. Yet, despite these difficulties, Joseph experienced the favor of God in his life. Through divine grace, each of his children was able to complete their education, which proves that God's grace is indeed sufficient for us.

In his mission work, Joseph encountered numerous challenges, particularly from those who were skeptical of his beliefs. At that time, the people of Nimtar were unfamiliar with the Christian faith and way of life, and many viewed it as a foreign religion, something they could not relate to at all. However, besides the initial criticism, Joseph never faced hostility or mistreatment. The people of Nimtar

welcomed him with kindness and respect, which helped create an environment conducive to his ministry.

Joseph remains deeply grateful to the people of Nimtar for their positive response. Their receptiveness to the mission provided encouragement to Joseph which has had a positive impact on the community.

In 1991, Joseph made his first journey to Nagaland to meet with the leaders of the Rengma Baptist Church. They welcomed him with warmth and kindness, yet there was a bittersweet aspect to his visit — he struggled to understand their language, which left him feeling isolated during their discussions. However, what stood out to Joseph was not the words he could not grasp, but the actions he witnessed.

During his time there, Joseph observed that the Nagamese people, though not wealthy, had hearts full of devotion to God's mission. They toiled in the paddy fields, earning modest wages, yet they supported him generously out of their deep commitment to the cause. This display of selflessness touched Joseph deeply, and he came to fully appreciate the value of their financial support, recognizing the sacrifice that it represented.

Moved by their dedication, Joseph made a firm decision in his heart to learn the Naga language. He chose to stay in Nagaland for a month, immersing himself in the local culture and practising the language daily with the people around him. With

each passing day, Joseph became more fluent in Nagamese, impressing the local leaders with his determination and perseverance. His resolve to overcome the language barrier proved that he was committed to his mission and reflected his deep respect for the community that had welcomed him so warmly.

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Chapter Six

Joseph and His Major Works

This chapter delves into the significant contributions that Joseph has made to the churches in Sikkim and the Sikkimese society as a whole. His impact on both the church and the broader community is immeasurable, so much so that capturing the full scope of his work in a single chapter would be an impossible task. My words may fall short of capturing the entirety of his achievements. However, I invite you to take a panoramic view of his most significant endeavors.

To present his work in a structured manner, the author of this book has divided his major contributions into seven distinct sections, each reflecting a different aspect of his legacy. We will explore these sections one by one, thereby gaining insight into the lasting influence he has had on the Christian community and the Sikkimese society at large.

1. Church Planting

His heart has always been devoted to the mission of church planting. What began as a humble effort in a small room has now blossomed into a movement that spans every corner of Sikkim, West Bengal, and even Nepal. The journey of his mission work began with the planting of his first church in Nimtar in East Sikkim in 1992. From there, his unwavering dedication led him to South Sikkim, where he established his second church in Nandu Gaon in South Sikkim.

Today, by the grace of God, the Baptist mission has flourished, with 23 churches established across Sikkim. Of these, five have chosen to forge their own paths in serving God. In West Bengal, the Baptist mission has founded six churches, which are now under the diligent care of Rev. Narayan Joshua. These six congregations have united under the West Bengal Baptist Mission, continuing to grow and serve their communities.

In Nepal, the Baptist mission has planted one church, which remains active and continues to thrive under the guidance of a dedicated missionary. His legacy of faith and service continues to resonate across these regions, as the seeds he planted bear fruit in the lives of countless believers.

He once reflected, “Planting a new church in a new place has been the most challenging mission of my life.” Though his heart yearns to build more churches, he admits that his advancing age has resulted in diminished strength, making it difficult for him to walk long distances and engage with new communities.

Throughout his ministry, he has had to face numerous trials and tribulations. On many occasions, he encountered opposition from within the very churches he sought to establish, but he acknowledges that he also made some mistakes along the way — some knowingly, others inadvertently. Yet, he views these missteps as valuable lessons, remarking, “My mistakes were like my Bible college; they taught me so much.”

Today, due to his health, Joseph Tamang primarily attends the Nimtar and Gangtok Baptist churches, as he can no longer endure long journeys. Despite the

physical limitations of age, his enduring commitment to the mission field demonstrates his unwavering faith and dedication.

2. **School Ministry**

Though he himself has had no formal education, he was determined that other children should not grow up without one. He harbored a deep desire to build a school but lacked the knowledge of how to start and run one.

One morning in the year 1997, as he was enjoying the warmth of the sun outside his home, he noticed a man coming towards him. When the man drew closer, he recognized him as Hemlal Chettri. Hemlal, who had a shared passion for education, encouraged Joseph to build a school. Hemlal was deeply committed to the idea of starting a school in his village and had already donated his land to the Nimtar Government School. Joseph said jokingly, "If you bring me 25 students tomorrow morning, then I'll build a school in this village." He felt sure that Hemlal Chettri would not be able to fulfil such a challenge.

However, the next morning, while Joseph was busy in the kitchen, he heard a commotion outside his house. Curious, he stepped outside and was astonished to find Hemlal Chettri standing there with almost 30 children around him. Surprised and impressed, Joseph realized he had no choice but to follow through on his promise. That day, he made the decision to start a school.

He sent a message to the Rengma Baptist Church in Nagaland, sharing the story of Hemlal and the eager children. Moved by this account, the Rengma Baptist Church responded by sending a teacher for the proposed school. With this support,

Joseph started a school in his own home. What began as a humble effort has grown into a thriving institution, now serving over 100 students with a staff of more than 10 teachers. Today, the school offers classes up to grade 7. Word of this success reached Nandu Goan, where the local panchayat invited Joseph to their village, requesting that he establish a school there as well. By the grace of God, Joseph was able to build another Baptist English School in Nandu Goan. This school, too, has flourished, now providing education to over 100 students and offers classes up to grade 6.

Now in his old age, he no longer has the strength he once did. Yet, whenever he sees students arriving at his school, dressed in their uniforms and carrying their books, he sees a reflection of his 6-year-old self in each of them. Although his family's circumstances prevented him from studying beyond the fourth grade, God has used his life to help other students fulfill their dreams.

3. Rehabilitation Center

Joseph Tamang was deeply engrossed in his mission when he began to notice troubling signs in his younger son, Simon. Despite Joseph's best efforts to guide Simon away from the bad company he had fallen into, all his attempts met with failure. The more he witnessed Simon's lifestyle deteriorate, the more his heart grew heavy with despair.

One day, Joseph heard about the Kripa Rehabilitation Center in Darjeeling. He had no understanding of how a rehabilitation center addresses this problem, but with the hope that it might offer a solution, he managed to convince Simon to give it a

try. They traveled to Darjeeling, with Joseph praying that this would be a turning point for his son.

Upon their arrival, Joseph was struck by the sight of so many young boys and girls from Sikkim, each lost in their own struggles, much like Simon. As he looked at them, Joseph saw his own son in their faces, and he felt a deep connection to the pain their parents also seemed to have been enduring. It was in that moment, while standing in the midst of those troubled youth, that Joseph resolved to take action. He decided then and there that Sikkim needed its own rehabilitation center — a place where others like Simon could find the help that they desperately needed, and where their families might find hope once again.

Starting the rehabilitation center proved to be an immense challenge for Joseph Tamang. With barely any funds for the plan, the dream seemed far out of reach. However, fate intervened when he crossed paths with Prem Singh Tamang, who was then the Social Welfare Minister of Sikkim. Today, Prem Singh Tamang is now known as the Chief Minister of Sikkim, but back then, he was someone who listened attentively to Joseph's vision. Joseph shared about his dream of establishing a rehabilitation center in Sikkim with sincerity and passion. Moved by his determination and recognizing the importance of the cause, Prem Singh Tamang offered his support. He provided the resources necessary to construct the rehabilitation center, a crucial first step that made Joseph's vision a reality.

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Prem Singh Tamang, also known as 'Golay Sir' at the Ribbon-cutting Ceremony at the Rehabilitation Center at Nimtar

During his tenure as a minister, Prem Singh Tamang — fondly known as Golay Sir — was a beacon of hope for countless people, who helped turn their dreams into reality. Now, as the Chief Minister of Sikkim, his impact has only grown, and he has truly become a savior for the needy and the sick. His leadership has touched the lives of countless people in various ways.

Joseph Tamang, reflecting on the immense contributions of the Chief Minister, expressed his deep gratitude, saying, "His Excellency has not only helped but has saved thousands of young lives. Through the establishment of this center, he has wiped away the tears of thousands of parents who had lost hope. His compassion and dedication have brought light to the darkest corners of our community, and for

that, we will forever be grateful.” Joseph's words resonate with many other people as well.

After establishing the rehabilitation center, Joseph Tamang faced a major challenge for the first two years. Not even a single patient came to his center, and the weight of the failure of his efforts began to feel overwhelming. Despite the substantial investment of time, money, and energy, Joseph found himself struggling with the uncertainty of how to attract the attention of those in need of this facility. His frustration grew as people around him began to mock his efforts, questioning why he had chosen such an isolated location by the river. Some even suggested that he abandon his mission and start a poultry or piggery farm instead. These dismissive remarks cut deep, breaking Joseph’s heart into pieces.

But just when his despair threatened to consume him, a glimmer of hope appeared. One afternoon, four people arrived at his home, bringing with them a patient from Gangtok—the first patient to seek help at his center. Joseph was overjoyed, as it marked the beginning of something he had only dreamed of. Slowly, more patients began to arrive, and he saw the fruits of his labor take root. Today, the center is home to over 60 patients.

Reflecting on this journey, Joseph said, "My younger son's struggles plunged me into darkness, but it was in that very darkness that a light was kindled. God's grace

has been my guiding force, helping me not only to save my own son but also to extend that salvation to countless other sons and daughters through this center."

Joseph's story is one of resilience, faith, and an unshakeable belief in the power of having a higher purpose in life, which has transformed his vision into a sanctuary for those in need.

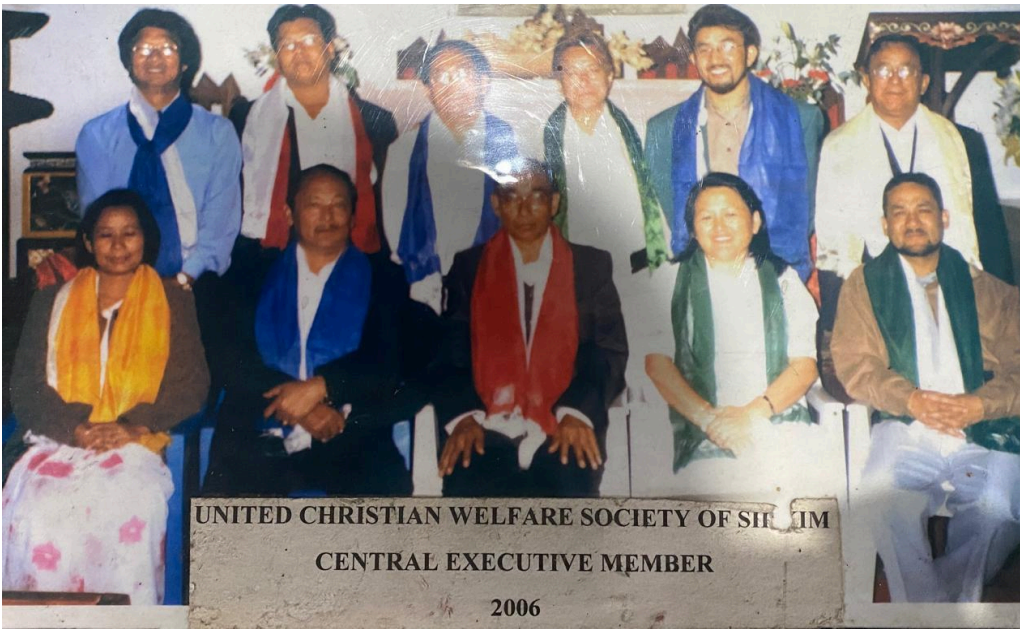
4. **The Genesis of United Christian Welfare Society of Sikkim**

On January 23, 1999, in the village of Manoharpur in Keonjhar District of Odissa, a horrific tragedy unfolded when a mob of Hindu extremists brutally burned alive an Australian missionary, Graham Stuart Staines, along with his two young sons, Philip and Timothy, as they slept in their car. The shocking news reverberated across India, igniting outrage and grief, especially among the Christian community. In Sikkim, the atrocity galvanized church leaders, who convened to discuss a collective response. They decided to organize a candlelight march in support of the Staines family and to stand against the violence that had claimed their lives.

During the meeting, a pivotal question was raised by Rev. Joseph: Under which banner would they march? He pointed out that a single church could not take to the streets independently. Moreover, to request permission from the government for such a march, they needed to present a unified front. This led to a significant decision — the formation of the United Christian Welfare Society of Sikkim (U.C.W.S.S.), a

body that would act as the mediator between the Sikkim government and the Christian churches of the region.

The inaugural meeting of the U.C.W.S.S. saw the election of Shri Andrew Rai from the Evangelical Presbyterian Church as its first President, with Rev. Joseph serving as the Vice President. The primary objective of this new organization was to protect the Christian community in Sikkim from persecution and to assist church leaders in getting their churches reegistered with the government. Rev. Joseph later served as President of the U.C.W.S.S. for a decade, during which period the society made significant strides, including bringing the renowned gospel singer Vijay Benedict to Sikkim, further strengthening the unity and resolve of the Christian community in the region.



First UCWSS Central Executive Body

5. Israel Visit

For many Christians, visiting Israel is a lifelong dream, as the country holds a great significance as the birthplace of Jesus Christ and the cradle of their faith. Rev. Joseph Tamang was no exception; he longed to walk the holy ground that had shaped the very foundation of Christianity. In 2019, this dream became a reality, thanks to the support of the then Chief Minister of Sikkim, Pawan Kumar Chamling.

Recognizing the deep spiritual connection that Christians have with Israel, Chief Minister Chamling entrusted Rev. Joseph with the responsibility of organizing a

pilgrimage to the Holy Land. With a generous funding from the Chief Minister, Rev. Joseph took the initiative to gather a group of 50 church leaders from different congregations from all over Sikkim. This diverse group, united in faith, embarked on an unforgettable journey to Israel.

For Rev. Joseph, this pilgrimage was not just a personal milestone but a collective achievement for the Christian leaders of Sikkim. He often reflects on the experience as one of the most cherished memories of his life. While standing on the places where Jesus was born and where He carried out His earthly mission and was crucified, Rev. Joseph felt a profound connection to his faith, seeing firsthand the sacred sites that have inspired countless generations.

6. **Graveyard at Gangtok**

In Gangtok, the Christian community faced a big challenge: finding a place to bury their deceased. As the capital of Sikkim, Gangtok had seen its jungles rapidly transform into a bustling town, driving up land prices to astronomical levels. By 2009, this issue had become so pressing that the Christians of Gangtok elected Rev. Joseph Tamang as the President of the Graveyard Committee, entrusting him with the daunting task of securing a burial ground.

Rev. Joseph understood the gravity of the situation and began to ponder deeply on how to address this urgent need. One day, he shared a vision with the Christian community — a vision of acquiring a plot of land in Chanmari, Gangtok,

measuring approximately 6 acres, and costing around ₹1.48 Cr. Raising such an enormous sum seemed almost impossible. However, when Rev. Joseph presented his vision to the churches of Gangtok, the pastors and their congregations responded with remarkable generosity, contributing whatever they could toward the cause.

Despite their wholehearted efforts, the funds collected fell short of the required amount. It was then that G.T. Dhungel, the current Health Minister of Sikkim, took notice of the situation. Moved by the plight of the community, he brought the issue to the attention of the Sikkim government. With the combined support of the state government and Shri G.T. Dhungel, Rev. Joseph was able to not only purchase the land but also oversee the construction of the necessary facilities on the land.

Reflecting on this achievement, Rev. Joseph often describes it as nothing short of miraculous. In his words, "What is impossible for man is possible with God." The successful acquisition of the burial land stands as a testament to his faith and determination, as well as the unity and resilience of the Christian community in Gangtok.

7. Sikkim Bible College

In Sikkim, the lack of a proper Bible college for aspiring Christian students has long been a pressing issue. Recognizing this need, Rev. Joseph Tamang felt a strong calling to establish such an institution. However, he faced a serious challenge — having never attended a Bible college himself, he was unsure of where to begin. Driven by his

vision, he shared his dream with Sanjiv Rai, the author of this biography and a scholar pursuing a Ph.D. in Theology. Remarkably, Sanjiv shared the same vision, which strengthened their resolve to bring this dream to life.

Today, Rev. Joseph is working tirelessly to establish a Bible college in Sikkim. The journey has been anything but easy, as they currently lack both land and a dedicated college building. Despite these challenges, Rev. Joseph remains undeterred. He has secured temporary permission from the Baptist Church in Sirwani to run short-term Bible courses, laying the foundation for what he hopes will become a permanent institution.

Rev. Joseph often expresses his concern about the passage of time, acknowledging that his strength is waning with each passing day. It is his deep desire to see this project completed before age catches up with him. As he would be the first president of the Sikkim Bible College, he has already made significant personal sacrifices and has also contributed a considerable amount of his own funds to support the training of underprivileged students.

Through this writing, Rev. Joseph Tamang and Sanjiv Rai extend an earnest appeal to the readers: to join them in this noble task of building a Bible college for the future Christian students of Sikkim who wish to pursue Theology. They envision Sikkim as a theological and philosophical hub for scholars, a place where future leaders of faith will be nurtured and equipped to make a difference in the world. Your

support, whether financial or otherwise, can help turn this vision into a reality. Let us build a lasting legacy together for the Christian community in Sikkim, one that will inspire generations to come.

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A Journey of Grace: Trusting in God's Plan

Final Message from Rev. Joseph Tamang to the Readers

I am deeply thankful to Almighty God for bringing me into this world and guiding my steps throughout this journey. I want to express my heartfelt gratitude to my parents, especially my mother, who nurtured and cared for me. I also would like to thank my family for standing by me through every high and low. And how could I ever forget to thank my dear family at the Baptist churches of Sikkim? To all the pastors and church leaders, thank you for tending to the body of Christ with such devotion and love. You are more than just a community to me; you have become a part of my heart and soul.

I must also extend my sincere thanks to Sanjiv Rai, the author of this book, for taking the time to tell my story. Your efforts have been a blessing, and I am forever grateful.

I am just a fragile human being, with little knowledge of the world. I didn't even pass the fifth grade. Yet, if I am anything today, it is solely because of God's grace. The hero of my life is not me, but Christ, the one who has led me to green pastures. If God can use someone like me for His kingdom, I am confident that He can use you too.

Let me take this opportunity to ask for your forgiveness if I have ever hurt any of you with my words or actions. My intention was never to cause harm, but as you all know, we are all sinners, and I count myself among them. Please forgive me, and remember me as your friend, brother, grandfather, or father.

To all my beloved Baptist church members, we have shared a beautiful journey together. I do not know what the future holds, but I urge you all to continue running your spiritual race with unity and love. Stay together, respect your pastors, and let our church grow stronger, making our Savior pleased through our actions. Stand firm against false teachings, and remain united in Christ, so that no outside force can break your bond.

I ask that no one call me Pastor or Sir, I am your Bara, and I will always be your Bara. When you call me Bara, my heart fills with joy, for it reminds me that you have accepted me as a member of your family.

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There is so much more I want to say, but I must bring this message to a close. Before I do, I want to express my deep gratitude to Shri G.T. Dhungel and his family, especially Sir Dhungel, the Health Minister of Sikkim. Thank you, Sir, for helping me in so many ways throughout my life.

Thank you all from the bottom of my heart.

Your Bara,

Rev. Joseph.